REGULAR MEETING CEREMONIES

OPENING CEREMONY

All officers should be in uniform, each wearing an official Legion cap and the official badge of office. The commander shall announce the meeting is about to open. Officers shall take their stations. The commander shall seat those present with one rap of the gavel, and the sergeant-at-arms shall close the doors of the meeting hall. The commander shall then give three raps of the gavel, and all who are present shall stand at attention.

Post commander: "The color bearers will advance the colors."

As the color bearers start to advance, the commander gives the command to salute.

Post commander: "Hand salute."

If a bugler is available, sound "To the Colors." At its conclusion, the commander gives the command, "Two."

If no bugler is present, the command "Two" is given immediately after the colors have been posted.

Post commander: "The chaplain will offer prayer."

Post commander: "All members/guests in attendance shall remain standing with their cap removed and placed over the heart from the opening prayer, through the POW/MIA ceremony, and concluding with the Pledge of Allegiance."

In place of the following prayer, the chaplain may deliver one appropriate for the setting.

Chaplain: "Almighty God, Father of all mankind and Judge over nations, we pray Thee to guide our work in this meeting and in all our days. Send Thy peace to our nation and to all nations. Hasten the fulfillment of Thy promise of peace that shall have no end.

"We pray for those who serve the people and guard the public welfare, that by Thy blessing they may be enabled to discharge their duties honestly and well. We pray that by Thy help they may observe the strictest justice, keep alight the fires of freedom, strive earnestly for the spirit of democracy, and preserve untarnished our loyalty to our country and to Thee. Finally, O God of mercy, we ask Thy blessing and comfort for those who are suffering mental and physical disability. Cheer them and bring them the blessings of health and happiness. Amen."

POW/MIA EMPTY CHAIR

This ceremony is a suggested outline that can be followed when an American Legion organization wants to call attention to Americans still unaccounted for from all wars and conflicts. Resolution No. 288, adopted at the Legion's 67th National Convention, calls for designating an empty chair at all official American Legion meetings as a continual physical symbol of POW/MIAs and the cause for which we stand, namely their return or full accounting.

Post commander: "A POW/MIA empty chair is placed at all official meetings of The American Legion as a physical symbol of many American POW/MIAs still unaccounted for from all wars and conflicts involving the United States of America. This is a reminder for all of us to spare no effort to secure the release of any American prisoners from captivity, the repatriation of the remains of those who died bravely in defense of liberty, and a full accounting of those missing. Let us rededicate ourselves to this vital endeavor!"

Post commander: "Place the POW/MIA flag on the empty chair."

The first and second vice commanders, or other designated individuals, approach the empty chair carrying a folded POW/MIA flag. Upon reaching the chair, they reverently unfold the flag and drape it over the chair with the crest facing the membership. After the meeting is concluded, the POW/MIA flag should be refolded and stored for future use.

The commander (or appropriate official) leads the assembly in the Pledge of Allegiance. Legionnaires will remove their caps. The commander may also direct the singing of "The Star-Spangled Banner."

"I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America and to the Republic for which it stands, one Nation under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all."

Regular meeting opening resumes after the Pledge of Allegiance.

Post commander: "Everyone will re-cover."

The commander and membership recite the preamble of the Constitution of The American Legion slowly and in unison, as follows:

"For God and Country, we associate ourselves together for the following purposes:

"To uphold and defend the Constitution of the United States of America;

"To maintain law and order;

"To foster and perpetuate a one hundred percent Americanism;

"To preserve the memories and incidents of our associations in all wars;

"To inculcate a sense of individual obligation to the community, state and nation;

"To combat the autocracy of both the classes and the masses;

"To make right the master of might;

"To promote peace and good will on earth;

"To safeguard and transmit to posterity the principles of justice, freedom and democracy;

"To consecrate and sanctify our comradeship by our devotion to mutual helpfulness."

The commander seats members with one rap of the gavel.

Post commander: "I now declare _____ Post No. _____, Department of _____, regularly convened."

The order of business for post meetings shall be:

a. Roll call to determine if quorum is present

b. Reading of minutes of previous meeting

c. Introduction of guests and prospective and new members

d. Committee reports

e. Balloting on applications

f. Sick call, relief and employment

g. Post service officer's report

h. Unfinished business

i. Initiation of candidates

j. New business and correspondence

k. Memorial to a departed post member

l. The good of The American Legion

The membership shall be permitted to make suggestions of any kind, character or description, save religion or partisan politics.

CLOSING CEREMONY

Post commander: "Is there any further business to come before the meeting? If not, the chaplain will lead us in memorial service."

The commander gives three raps of the gavel, and the membership rises, uncovers and stands in silence.

Chaplain: "Our Heavenly Father, we deem this a fitting time to pay our respects to our departed comrades. As we stand with bowed heads in reverence to them, let us remember the good deeds they accomplished. Let us revere them as good soldiers who fought the good fight in a just cause. Let us silently pray for peace, the peace that passes all understanding. And let us in mind and soul consecrate our hearts and lives to the real America, the land of the free and the home of the brave, the America worth fighting for. As we stand in silence to our departed comrades, may we sincerely say, 'May their souls rest in peace.' Let us also remember the POWs and the MIAs still unaccounted for from the wars and conflicts. Amen."

Post commander: "Cover."

Sounding taps will add greatly to the solemnity of the ritual. The first stanza of "America," "My Country, 'Tis of Thee" or another patriotic selection may be sung by the audience.

Post commander: "Sergeant-at-arms, recover the POW/MIA flag."

The sergeant-at-arms steps forward, picks up the POW-MIA flag off the chair, folds the flag, steps back and places the POW-MIA flag on the table in front of the commander.

"Till we meet again let us remember our obligation to our country can be fulfilled only by the faithful performance of all duties of citizenship. Let service to the community, state and nation be ever a main objective of The American Legion and its members. Let us be ever watchful of the honor of our country, our organization and ourselves, that nothing shall swerve us from the path of Justice, Freedom and Democracy. The color bearers will retire the flag of our country."

As the color bearers retrieve the colors, the commander shall give the command to salute.

Post commander: "Hand salute."

As the color bearers reach the rear of the meeting hall, the commander says, "Two."

Post commander: "I now declare this meeting of _____ Post No._____, The American Legion, Department of _____ adjourned."

The commander gives one rap of the gavel.